



8 tools for your Tough Days

Small, practical things that actually help, whatever job you do.

1

If you're feeling flat, maybe it's not just tired.

Tired is normal, everyone feels it after a long day. Flat is different, when things that usually pull you out of a bad mood, a good song, a laugh with a mate, footy on the weekend, stop doing that for you, your body's telling you something more is going on. That's not weakness, and it's not something you're meant to just push through. Here's one small thing to try: pick something you used to enjoy and give it three minutes a day, whether you feel like it or not. Stick with it and it's often one of the small things that helps people feel more like themselves again. You can't run on an empty tank forever, so it's worth topping up your own before you try to fill everyone else's.

2

Mark the end of your shift.

Drive home a different way, even if it's longer. Put your phone on do not disturb for twenty minutes. Play your favourite music loudly in the car and sing along, anything that tells your brain the day is actually over, not just your roster. Get out of your work clothes, make a tea or coffee. Most people carry their work home with them because nothing marked the moment the day ended. Pick a few things you'll actually do each time you walk in the door, so your mind and body know you're home.

3

Protect the first twenty minutes home.

Do tip two first, then rest before you get stuck into chores. Play with your kids, talk to your partner, chat with a mate. You've just spent eight, ten, twelve hours meeting other people's demands. Twenty minutes for yourself first isn't selfish, it's the difference between showing up for the people you love running on empty, or running on something.

4

Take real breaks, not just pretend ones.

Three minutes of walking around the house or office every hour, a walk outside, making a tea or coffee, beats pushing straight through and calling it efficient. Your body doesn't register 'I didn't stop' as strength, it registers it as using up everything you had left. Short, regular breaks aren't slacking off, they're what keep you going at the pace the job actually needs from you.



8 tools for your Tough Days, continued

5

Tell one person, not everyone.

You don't need to explain yourself to your colleagues, a group chat or your entire family. One honest conversation with someone you actually trust, even just 'today was harder than usual,' does more than staying quiet and hoping it passes. Most people overestimate how much they'd need to say about how tough their day's been, and underestimate how much even one sentence can lift them.

6

Schedule meaningful connection, don't wait for it.

If your work is solitary, long haul, shift work, FIFO, remote sites, pick a set time each day to check in with someone, even a two minute call can make a real difference. We're wired for connection, so remember that talking ain't weak.

7

Do something that's just for you.

Even three minutes counts. Music in the car before you walk in the door. Five minutes with a hobby that has nothing to do with anyone else's needs. It's not selfish and it's not indulgent, it's what keeps the tank from running on empty week after week.

8

Don't decide big life changes on a bad day.

If you're exhausted, flat or wound up, that's not the moment to decide whether to quit, walk away from a relationship or make a major call. Give yourself some space first, a good night's rest, a proper break, before you trust a decision made in a rush. The decision will still be there tomorrow. You just want to be the one making it, not the mood you were in when things got hard.